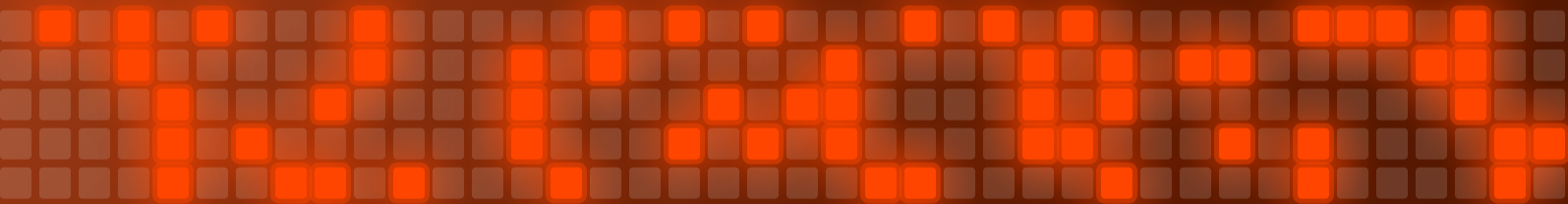
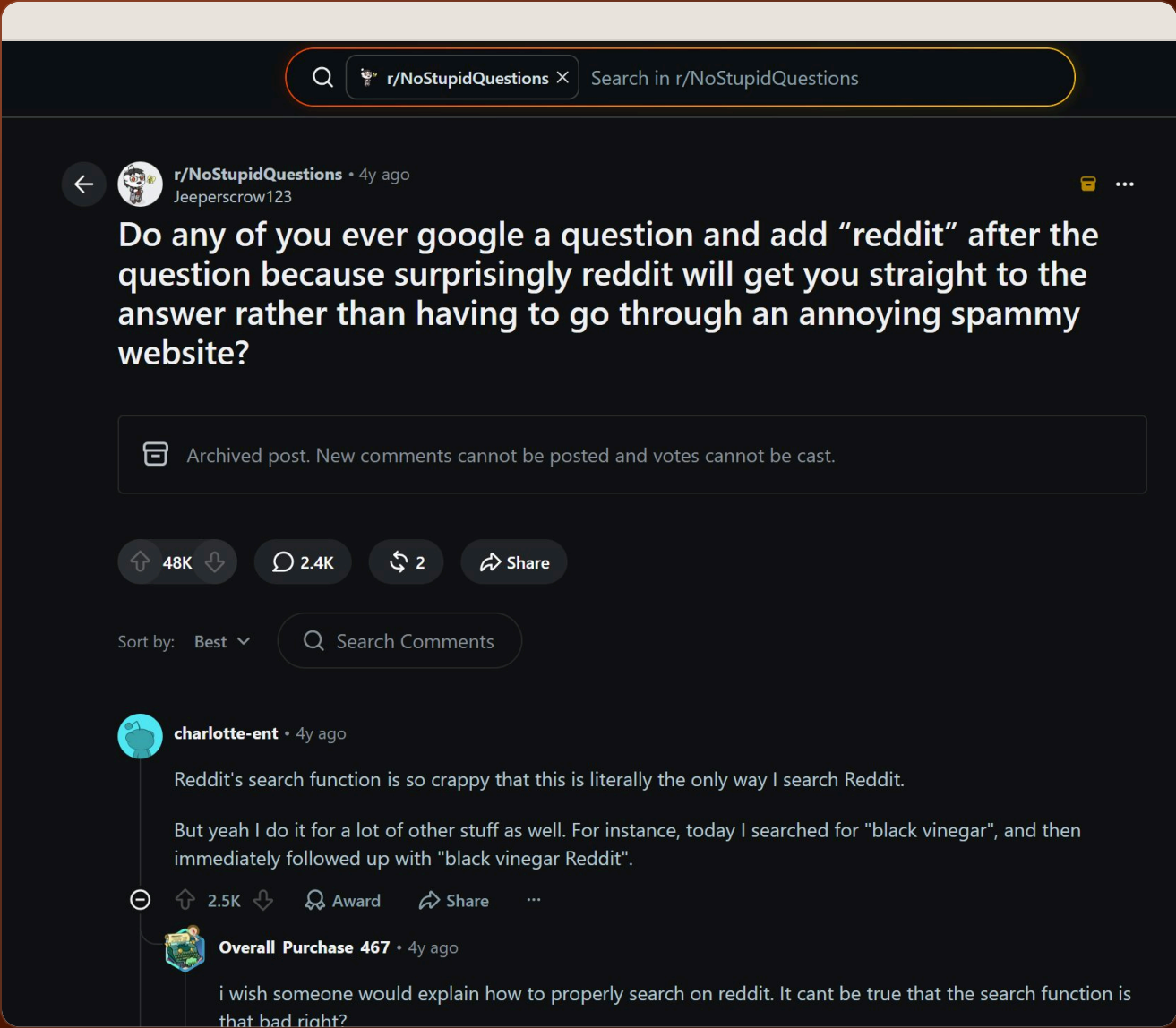


Reddit is read without being visited.

Reddit’s acquisition funnel opens on a Google results page it does not own. Something in the middle now answers the question using Reddit’s content, so the top of that funnel is closing while the reading carries on. Reddit sells the visit, not the answer.



■ 72 in 100 answered inside Google ■ 28 reach a website each square is one US Google search, Jan-Apr 2026



r/NoStupidQuestions · 48K upvotes · 2.4K comments. Behavioural testimony from 2021, not current traffic data.

Reddit's revenue is at a record. Its distribution is not.

Both facts come from the same quarter, and the market priced the second one.



What it is

More than 100,000 communities built on anonymous, community-level posts. The stated mission is community, belonging and empowerment.



How it earns

Q2 2026 revenue **\$805M**, up **61%**, an eighth straight quarter above 60%. Advertising is **\$762M** of that, or 95%. Data licensing is **\$39M**.



The tension

Advertising is priced against logged-in, returning users. The dominant entry is a one-off search landing. **Reddit earns nothing from a satisfied lurker and less than nothing from a satisfied non-visitor.**



The leverage

The Google licence, about **\$60M a year**, expires in **H1 2027**. Reddit is reported to be weighing whether to renew at all, and to want usage-based fees. The OpenAI renewal is also unresolved.

Reddit earns from one cohort and is increasingly made of the other

Both numbers are Reddit's own, reported for the same quarter.



LOGGED OUT

77.7M

DAU, up **27%**. Lands from search, reads one thread, leaves. No account, so no repeat-visit signal, no retention curve, and no lifetime value to price an ad against.



LOGGED IN

52.6M

DAU, up **7%**. Returns, retains, and can be sold to. Every advertising dollar is priced against this cohort. It grows four times slower than the one Reddit cannot bill.

Reddit’s arrival channel is squeezed at both ends

About **60%** of Reddit’s daily actives arrive logged out, and search is how most of them get there. Two different things are now squeezing that channel. **Google answers inside the results page, so the click never happens. AI assistants read the thread and answer without citing it, so the visit never happens either.** Huffman called Reddit’s search referrals **“choppy”** on the Q2 call.

SHARE OF US GOOGLE SEARCHES ENDING WITH NO CLICK TO ANY WEBSITE



The zero-click figures are Google-wide, not Reddit’s own: [SparkToro with Similarweb clickstream data](#), Jun 2026. They are on this slide because this is the channel Reddit’s logged-out majority arrives through. AI Overviews now appear on over 20% of searches. Every publisher on this channel is exposed: over the year to Jun 2026 USA Today lost nearly half its organic Google traffic and Politico lost 23% (Semrush). Huffman quotes: Reddit Q2 2026 earnings call, 30 Jul 2026.

WHAT REPLACED THE VISIT

ChatGPT read **16.18 million** Reddit pages and credited **1.93%** of them.

Reddit is the largest uncredited source in AI retrieval: **67.8%** of every URL ChatGPT pulls and does not cite belongs to Reddit. The model reads the thread, answers the user, and returns no session. Consumption without a session is consumption Reddit cannot measure, retain or monetise.

The job a summary cannot finish

If a summary already answers the question, the old job is finished before Reddit is reached. What survives summarising is the part a summary has to throw away: the disagreement, and the person who can be asked a follow-up.



PRIMARY PERSONA

Search-First Rohan

Search arrival, not idle browsing, is the dominant entry path. About 60% of Reddit's users are men, and the skew is sharpest among the people who actually post, which is the cohort the primary solution acts on.

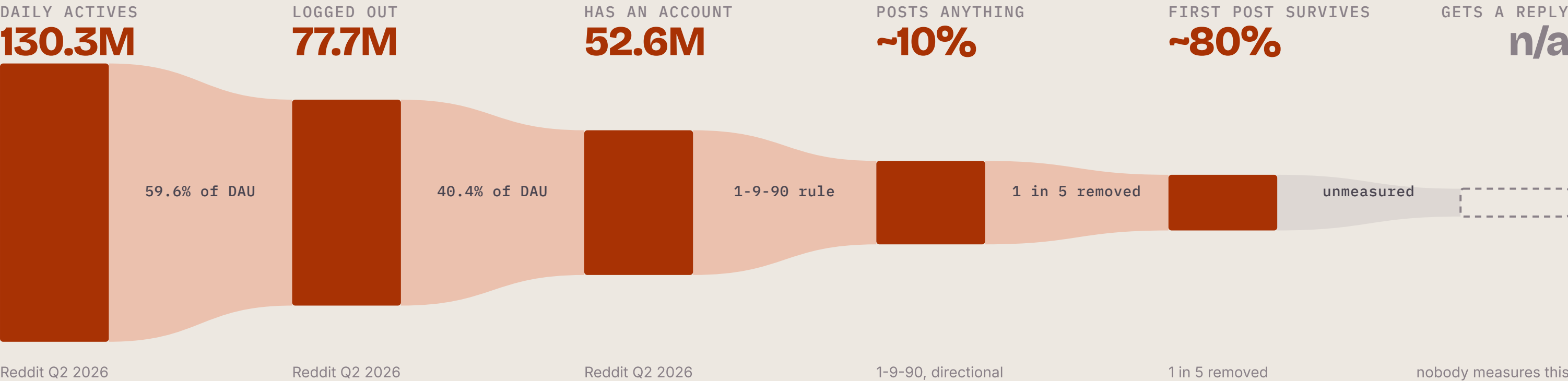
When an AI answer is close but not my case, **I want to reach the people it summarised**, because a summary cannot be asked a follow-up.

When the sources disagree, **I want to see the argument and not the verdict**, because one confident paragraph hides how contested the answer is.

When I finally have something worth adding, **I want to know the rules before I am judged by them**, not after my post has been deleted.

Every stage is smaller than the last, and the last one is not measured

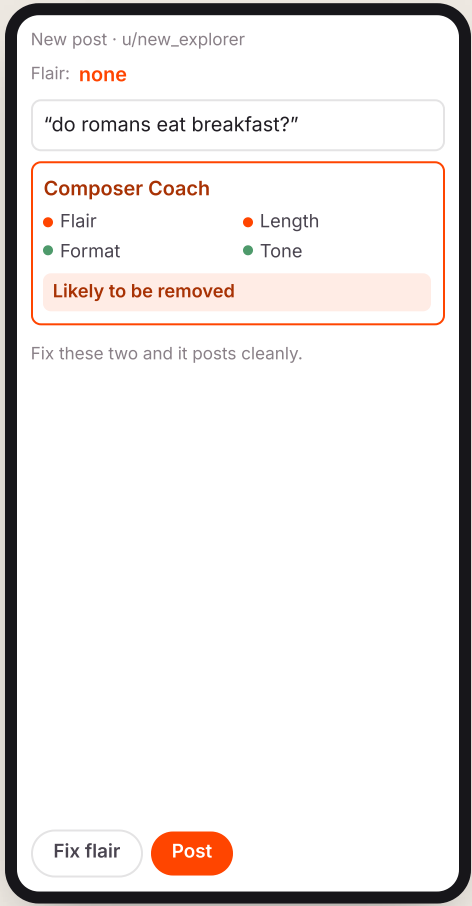
Reddit reports the first three. The next two come from published research. Nobody reports the last, which is where Solution 3 can look like a win and not be one.



Band widths are not to scale: each stage is roughly an order of magnitude smaller than the one before, and a true taper would draw the tail as a hairline. Stages 1–3: [Reddit Q2 2026](#). “Posts anything”: the 1-9-90 rule (NN/g, 2006), twenty years old and community-general, so directional only. “First post survives”: about a fifth of Reddit posts are removed, and 37% of the users whose post was removed did not understand why (Jhaver et al., ACM CSCW 2019, n=907). Reddit removed a little over 3% of all new content in H1 2024, of which 66.5% was spam.

Catch the bad first post before Automod does

Promoted to primary because it acts on **supply**, not on arrivals. Arrivals are shrinking for reasons Reddit does not control. The corpus is what survives the channel.



Mobile composer, checked live

What it is

A real-time check inside the composer for new accounts, under seven days old or low karma. It flags flair, length, formatting and tone **before** submit rather than after deletion.

Why it leads now

Logged-in DAU grows at **7%**. Logged-out grows at **27%**. A first post that survives is how the slow number moves. The posts are also the asset Reddit licenses, and **that licence is renegotiated in H1 2027**.

What it costs

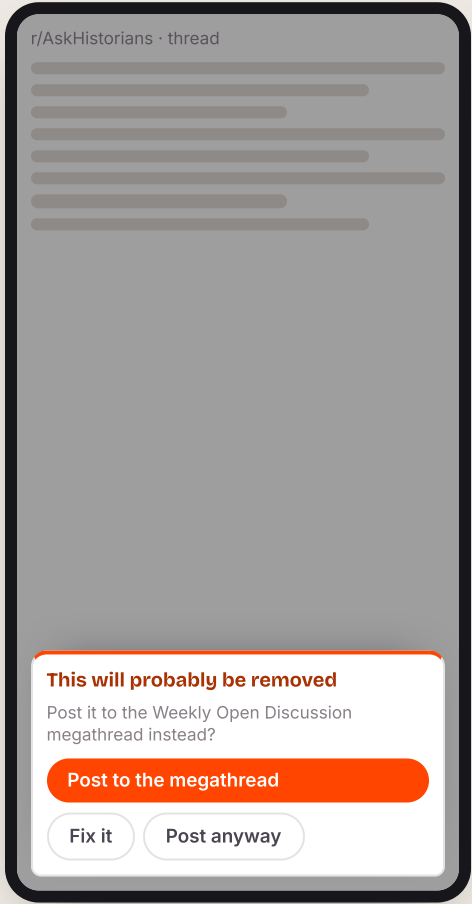
The rules linter is effectively free. An LLM check costs about **\$0.001**. Ship the linter first and add a model only for fuzzy tone. The week-one posting rate should come from internal data, and this deck does not assert it.

The dependency, stated up front

Automod rules are per-subreddit and often private. Many key on account age, karma floor or verified email, and **a composer cannot fix any of those**. Coach covers the machine-checkable subset. Full coverage needs a platform-level rule surface, out of scope here.

Then give the post somewhere to land

When Coach flags a likely removal, it offers the subreddit’s megathread instead. The sheet opens over the thread and does not block the post. A likely failure becomes a first post that publishes.



Bottom sheet over the live thread

Positioning

This sits inside the Coach flow. On its own it becomes a “kids table” for new accounts, which is worse than what it replaces.

If there is no megathread

Most subreddits do not run one. Those fall back to Coach’s fix guidance and a Reddit-wide new-contributor thread.

The metric risk

Most megathread comments get no reply. The north star metric would still count them, so the number goes up and the user gets nothing. **So I would also track the reply-received rate on a first post within 48 hours.**

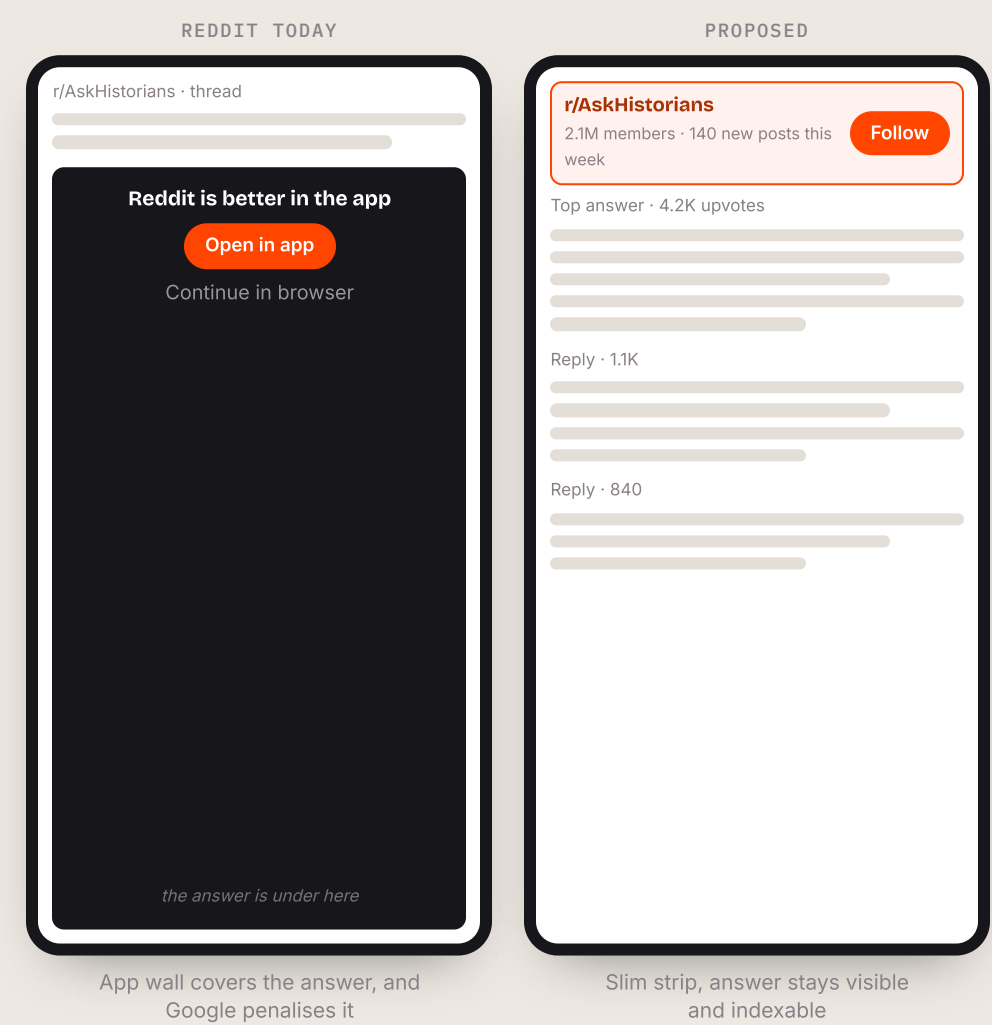
The relationship risk

Moderators may read this as routing around their rules. Their trust is Reddit’s most fragile asset. Ship to opt-in subreddits first and watch the mod-sentiment guardrail.

Framing from the 1-9-90 rule (NN/g, 2006): the hard part is moving a user from lurking to participating at all. The source is twenty years old and community-general, so treat it as directional.

Replace the app-install wall with thread-page onboarding

Sized honestly: this **protects yield on a falling channel**. It only acts on arrivals, so it cannot drive growth. It is still the cheapest thing to test.



- Community identity**
“r/AskHistorians · 2.1M members.” She sees where she is in one glance. Today the page assumes she already knows.
- Age-robust liveness**
“140 new posts this week.” Search surfaces old threads, so a live-user count reads zero on exactly the pages that need it most. A recency count survives age. Below a threshold, suppress the chip instead of showing a zero.
- One non-coercive CTA**
“Follow this community”, or “notify me if someone answers.” No signup wall. It creates a return trigger and a measurable conversion rate. **The original CTA asked a satisfied searcher to ask a question she no longer had.**
- What the evidence does not say**
Cross-industry popup data shows new visitors converting above returning ones, and mobile above desktop. Those are e-commerce email captures, not Reddit thread pages. The direction transfers and the magnitude does not. **This deck forecasts no lift.**

Hard constraints: non-intrusive, no app wall, no scroll block, 100% indexable. A non-blocking strip also stays clear of Google’s 2017 intrusive-interstitial penalty, which affects ranking and is separate from AI Overviews suppressing clicks. Mock reflects Reddit’s mobile web as observed Apr 2026, so re-verify before presenting.

One north star metric, and the guardrails that outrank it

Solution 1’s premise is that the valuable cohort never signs up, so an unchained north star under-credits it. Report the funnel, not the endpoint.

MEASURE	WHAT IT IS AND WHY	INSTRUMENT
North star metric	New user activation rate: the share completing one meaningful action, upvote, follow or comment, within 48 hours of signup. Chained for this cohort as thread-arrival → signup → 48h action.	Chained
Secondary	Time to first action. Subreddit follow rate on day one. Reply-received rate on a first post within 48 hours.	Activation
Guardrail • test design	Measure against concurrent holdout subreddits , not a year-on-year baseline. Referral traffic is volatile for outside reasons, and a YoY baseline cannot separate our treatment from a Google core update.	Holdouts
Guardrail • SEO	Thread content indexability stays at 100% . Every fix here touches the arrival surface, so every fix can threaten the traffic the business runs on.	100%
Guardrail • engagement	Scroll depth and dwell time must not fall. Bounce rate is the wrong instrument here , because a search-arrived single-thread session counts as a bounce by definition.	Not bounce
Guardrail • mods	Removal rate and mod-reported sentiment, per subreddit. Solutions 2 and 3 touch moderation directly, and mod trust is the asset least able to survive being spent.	Sentiment

And from Q3 2026 this goes dark. Reddit stops reporting logged-in and logged-out DAU, so the cohort this deck is about becomes unmeasurable from outside. It stays instrumented internally.

Ship the cheapest test first, and protect the traffic

Sequenced so the most expensive phase ships only if the cheap one proves it is needed.

Ship in this order

- + **Phase 1 · Coach baseline.** Non-LLM rules linter for new accounts, on opt-in subreddits. Watch Automod pass-rate lift and reply-received rate.
- + **Phase 2 · The strip.** A/B the Solution 1 thread-page strip on a few high-traffic subreddits against concurrent holdouts. Watch the SEO guardrail first and everything else second.
- + **Phase 3 · LLM and fallback.** Add model-based tone checks and the megathread fallback. Ships only if Phase 1 falls short.
- + Phases 1 and 2 are independent and can run at once. Phase 3 is conditional on Phase 1 by design, not by capacity.

Risks, and what holds them

- **The strip fatigues users or hurts engagement** → keep the design non-modal and hold the scroll-depth guardrail.
- **Coach reads as gatekeeping** → frame it as help, make it opt-out, limit it to new accounts.
- **Mods read Coach as undermining moderation** → opt-in subreddits first, and the mod-sentiment guardrail leads.
- **Solution 1's ceiling falls with the channel** → it protects yield and does not drive growth. Size it that way.
- **Progressive login blurs** were considered and cut. They would degrade the indexable content the whole business runs on. A rejected option, not a managed risk.

The visit itself, and why I am not pretending to fix it here

Three solutions act on people who reach the page. None act on the person who never arrives. That gap is real, so it is named here rather than filled with a fourth feature I could not evidence.

01	The lever	The only surface a non-visitor touches is what the crawler sees. Any genuine fix has to change what Reddit exposes to be summarised, not what it shows on a page the user never opens.
02	Why it is out of scope	This is a licensing and distribution decision before it is a product one. The Google contract expires H1 2027, Reddit is reported to want usage-based terms, and the OpenAI renewal is unresolved. That negotiation sets the terms, not a feature. A PM answering a contract problem with a content-structure change is bringing the wrong instrument.
03	What would change my mind	Whether retrieval fell or only citation fell. Reddit's share of ChatGPT citations dropped from 3.83% to 0.52% in four days in August, an 86.4% relative fall. But Ahrefs measured the same platform over the same window at 16.7%, Promptwatch calls its own figure provisional, and a near-identical collapse in June recovered within two months.
04	Why the deck is not built on that number	ChatGPT sends under 0.1% of Reddit's inbound. Google AI Overviews and AI Mode declined about 11% and 30% over the same window, a slope rather than a cliff. The loud number is the small one. The 68% zero-click figure is what moves the business.
05	Why product work is still the work	Licensing is not the escape hatch. It earned \$39M last quarter against \$762M from advertising. Double it and it still would not cover a falling ad line. The visit is what pays.

If retrieval fell rather than citation, this deck's thesis inverts: read without being paid becomes no longer read, a different and worse problem that none of these solutions address. Sources: Promptwatch citation tracking, Aug 2026; Ahrefs, Apr and Aug 2026.

REDDIT · READ WITHOUT BEING VISITED

Thank you.

Reddit's asset was never the answer. It was the argument underneath it. When the answer stops requiring a visit, the argument is the only thing left worth arriving for.